sensitivity was a mistake: by officially declaring the agreement to be defunct, the British government could start to repair the damage done to its reputation.[12] However, by leaving it neither enacted nor annulled, the agreement hung like an albatross around the neck of Anglo-Persian relations – a focus for anti-British feeling within Persia and for Britain a reminder of its failure to bring Persia under its control.

Norman was not alone in believing that his government should distance itself from the accord. Unsurprisingly, Chelmsford supported this view:

it seems to us essential that we should seize every possible opportunity of working back to our old role of champions of Islam against the Russian ogre. At present the roles are reversed and our position not only in Persia but throughout [the] Middle East is one of greatest difficulty in consequence. Scrapping of Anglo-Persian Agreement would go far to right the matter.

Curzon's minuted response was typical of the ill feeling he constantly displayed towards the viceroy:

Considering that the Gov. of India decline to take the slightest interest in Persia, have steadily opposed the Anglo-Persian Agreement from the start, cut off their expenditure there without even a reference to us, and wash their hands of all responsibility – I regard the above with which they so liberally regale us as an impertinence and would not pay it the compliment of a reply.[13]

But despite Curzon's dismissal of Chelmsford's opinion, the idea that the agreement was now worse than useless was growing within the British government. Even Sir Percy Cox, the chief architect of the agreement (and